This Tata–SIA proposal finally got FIPB approval in October 2013. It did not, however, go down well with Bhatia, who accused the Tatas of being ‘unethical’. The Tata Group denied that they had done any ‘backdoor deal’. Ratan felt that there was room for both the airlines to exist and flourish. He said in 2014: ‘There is an enormous potential for air travel in India at both ends of the spectrum both in the budget segment which AirAsia will serve, and for the full-service carrier which Singapore Airlines will bring to the country.’ Vistara received all approvals and made its first flight between Delhi and Mumbai in 2015. In two years, the Tatas now had stakes in two airlines.

Over the years, Tata Sons increased its stakes in AirAsia India. By 2020, it acquired 84 per cent ownership of the airline, giving it a ‘national tag’. The group policy is to ensure that no company is subscale, and this led to the infusion of additional capital in the airline, says Chandrasekaran. It did so in Vistara too. Once Tata invests, ‘it is a Tata commitment … exiting is not an option, slow burning and losing money is also not an option’, and the way forward is to achieve scale, he adds emphatically.

The Return of the Maharaja

The Narendra Modi government’s policy of disinvesting businesses that are better run by the private sector came as a grand denouement for Ratan. In 2017, the government decided to divest the loss-making Air India. Ratan and Chandrasekaran saw an ‘opportunity’ in the decision. As Chandrasekaran said in an interview with me, ‘Air India is more than a business for the Tatas. Air India is the nation’s pride, Tata’s pride.’ Echoing the Tata philosophy, he continues, ‘Sometimes you do not do business only for financial returns’, though ‘we will not run it without financial returns’.

After the government’s announcement, Chandrasekaran approached Ratan, whom he consults when he is faced with ‘any difficult thing’. ‘I run it past him [as] he may not offer advice unless you ask him,’ Chandrasekaran says.

When the Air India proposal was discussed with Ratan, he ‘did not show excitement’, nor did he say, ‘somehow we should do it’, says Chandrasekaran. But ‘he was extremely supportive’ and ‘wanted it to happen’, yet ‘he did not want to force’ the decision, the present chairman